The phenomenon of Islamic fundamentalism interested me, especially in light of my extensive experience in the war against Arab terrorism, which at the time was characterized by nationalistic, secular, and class motivations. Here are a few things I learned, things that I think all people in Western society who consider themselves educated should understand.

When fundamentalist Islam burst onto the world stage, with its notorious and distinctive representative Osama bin Laden, who presented an apocalyptic religious vision of the eradication of all infidels and the establishment of a global Muslim caliphate, thinkers, opinion makers, statesmen, and politicians around the world were caught off guard and therefore did not want to deal with the insight that the world of the late twentieth century was returning to the era of medieval religious wars.

According to Samuel P. Huntington's classic book *The Clash of Civilizations* (1996), "A resident of Rome may define himself with varying degrees of intensity as a Roman, an Italian, a Catholic, a Christian, a European, a Westerner. The civilization to which he belongs is the broadest level of identification with which he strongly identifies." Huntington lists the major civilizations of the world as Western, Confucian, Japanese, Islamic, Hindu, Slavic-Orthodox, South American (Latin), and African. He describes civilizations as differentiated from each other by history, language, culture, tradition, and, most important, religion.[3]

For over a decade after the terrorist attacks of September 11, 2001, Western leaders, intellectuals, and educated citizens had refrained from defining the conflict between the Western and Islamic civilizations, which the attacks had brought to the forefront of the global agenda, as religious. The reason for this was the primal fear of a return to the medieval religious wars. It seemed to me that Bush's much-publicized visit to the Islamic Center in Washington immediately after the terrorist attack was an indication of this fear.

Upon further thinking, it occurred to me that the phenomenon of fundamentalist Islam was not purely one of religious war. Perhaps it was more accurate to define it as engaging in a religious war against those who held different religious beliefs that adopted the values of freedom and modernity. Fundamentalist Muslims represented only a small minority of Islam's 1.3 billion (in 2010) believers. Moreover, both Shia and Sunni Salafi fundamentalist Muslims viewed the Muslim majority that did not share their beliefs as heretics against the true Islam who must be fought,